the most precarious of work—a problem made worse as the extremists threaten anyone from the Rakhine community who deals with the Rohingyas.[70]

Such conditions of poverty, as is usually the case, hit women the hardest. Lacking healthcare, they tend to become pregnant[71] due to lack of access to any form of family planning, a situation which has become much worse since the expulsion of MSF from the country.[72] While many children die at an early age, perversely, the high birth rate in the Rohingya community is partly the fault of those extremists who then cite it as evidence of the threat to 'Buddhist' Myanmar (although note that the actual birth rate of the Rohingyas is hotly disputed). Even among the more moderate Buddhists there is now a fear that Muslims will 'outbreed' the Buddhists, diluting the Buddhist nature of Myanmar.[73]

The 2015 refugee crisis

If the level of outright violence in Rakhine dropped after 2013, persecution and exclusion continued unabated. There is now strong evidence that the Myanmar regime has decided to make the internal refugee camps permanent,[74] as the Rohingyas are to be displaced from the urban areas of Rakhine. The 2014 census, for example, is being used for this purpose: 'the authorities will construct temporary camps in required numbers for those who refuse to be registered and those without adequate documents and sequester them in closed camps in what amounts to arbitrary, indefinite detention with the possibility of deportation'.[75]

The 2014 census will be discussed in detail later on, as it had a major impact on the conduct of the 2015 elections. For the moment, it is sufficient to note that the Myanmar authorities simply refused to allow those Rohingyas who did not identify as 'Bengali' to complete the census. This has led to the removal of any remaining identification cards, and the resulting lack of adequate documentation is used as an excuse to force the Rohingyas into the refugee camps.

The systemic misery of the Rohingyas' lives is fuelling a massive refugee crisis with many seeking to escape by sea to neighbouring countries. This outflow of people has been a regular response to periods of systemic persecution and has become a regular feature of the spring post-